

all suffered it. If you are just starting out, be wise and learn from the mistakes of others.

Considering all these issues and to avoid palpitations in the future, it's a good idea to have a signed contract with your client. If you just cringed at the mention of a contract and visualised lawyer meetings, attorney fees or learning legalese, that's a perfectly acceptable and understandable reaction. But completely unnecessary. You don't need a lawyer to draft a contract, or learn Vulcan, just a word doc outlining the terms of the agreement in simple English is good enough. Read on to understand the important clauses you should include in a contract.

Scope of work

This is a no brainer. Talk to the client, understand their requirements and outline them in the contract. Try not keep it open ended and put in as much detail as you can. Outline exactly what the client can expect from you.

An example is "Creating a company logo for XXX. The logo should include company colours blue, red and yellow and reflect the groundbreaking technological research being done by the company through representation of Nikola Tesla or his inventions. There will be 3 designs submitted out of which one will be finalised."

If there are any technical specifications or samples have been given by the client to be used as reference points, mention them as included in an appendix and attach those documents at the end of the contract. This vacillates against the slimy bug called "scope creep". Scope creep are minor revisions to the project, like "OK so you have designed a Tesla coil on a microchip, that's great. Could you also add in a bulb with a glowing edge". Sounds like a small request but then it never stops. One after the other after the other and it just snowballs and drowns you. Avoid this pitfall and be as detailed as possible about in this clause.

Charges

This is the sticky point and the cause for many a headaches later. Be as detailed as you can or need to be. Specify how the charges are to be calculated, if you are going to be paid per word, per design or by hour? Mention if taxes, like GST, are applicable on the rates or are they inclusive of all taxes. Make sure that both of you agree on a calculation methodology or a lump sum fee amount. Being on the same page at the time of signing the contract means there will no fuss when you raise the final invoice.